

DEPRESSION: DIAGNOSIS

Has patient had 1 or more of the following core features of depression for at least 2 weeks?

- Depressed mood most of the day, nearly every day
- Loss of interest or pleasure in activities that are usually pleasurable

Yes

Has patient had 5 or more of the following features of depression for at least 2 weeks?

- Depressed mood most of the day, nearly every day
- Loss of interest or pleasure in activities that are usually pleasurable
- Fatigue or loss of energy
- Disturbed sleep or sleeping too much
- Change in appetite or weight
- Feeling guilty or worthless
- Reduced concentration or indecisiveness
- Visible agitation or restlessness or talking or moving more slowly than usual
- Ideas or acts of self-harm or suicide

No

Yes: does the patient have difficulty carrying out ordinary work, domestic or social activities?

No

Yes

Check for anaemia

If pallor, check Hb.
If < 12 (woman) or
< 13 (man), **anaemia**
likely → 27.

Check for thyroid disease

If weight gain, dry skin,
constipation or cold
intolerance, check TSH. If
abnormal, refer to doctor.

Screen for substance misuse

In the past year, has patient: 1) drunk
≥ 4 drinks¹/session, 2) used illegal drugs or
3) misused prescription or over-the-counter
medications? If yes to any → 142.

Check for medication side effects

Review medication: prednisone,
efavirenz, metoclopramide, theophylline
and contraceptives can cause
depression. Discuss with specialist.

No

Continue to assess and manage the
patient with low mood, stress or
anxiety → 86.

If none of above or depressive symptoms persist despite treatment: does the patient have any psychotic symptoms²?

Yes

Refer same day.

No

Check if known bipolar disorder or symptoms of mania (now or in the past): 3 or more of the following for ≥ 1 week
and interfered with ordinary work, domestic or social activities?

- Elevated mood and/or irritability
- Decreased need for sleep
- Inappropriate social behaviour
- Easily distracted
- Increased activity, feeling of increased energy, talkative, rapid speech
- Impulsive/reckless behaviour like excess spending, thoughtless decisions, sexual indiscretion
- Inflated self esteem

No: has there been a major loss or bereavement within last 6 months?

Yes

Yes: does patient have ideas of suicide or self-harm, feelings of worthlessness or
is s/he talking or moving unusually slowly?

No

Bipolar disorder
likely.

No: has patient had depression in the past?

Yes

Discuss/refer.

No: symptoms likely due to loss/bereavement. Provide
support → 86. If persists ≥ 6 months, discuss/refer.

Yes

Depression likely → 144.

¹One drink is 1 tot of spirits, or 1 small glass (125mL) of wine or 1 can/bottle (330mL) of beer. ²Psychotic symptoms include any of: hallucinations (hearing voices/seeing things that are not there); delusions: (unusual/bizarre beliefs not shared by society; beliefs that thoughts are being inserted or broadcast); disorganised speech (incoherent or irrelevant speech); behaviour that is disorganised or catatonic (inability to talk, move or respond).